

HANDOUT 4: Strengths-Based Language Cheat Sheet

A quick reference for professional, family-centered communication.

STARTING WITH STRENGTHS

- "One thing I really love about [child's name] is..."
- "I've noticed that [he/she/they] really excels at..."
- "Families always know their child best, and I'd love to hear what you've seen."
- "I'm so grateful to have [child's name] in our program."

SHARING OBSERVATIONS

- "Over the past few weeks, I've noticed..."
- "I've been documenting some patterns I'd like to share with you."
- "Here is what I observed, along with the date and situation."
- "I want to be transparent with you about what I'm seeing."

ASKING FAMILY-CENTERED QUESTIONS

- "What does this look like at home?"
- "What works really well for your child?"
- "What does [he/she/they] love most?"
- "Is there anything going on that might be helpful for me to know?"
- "What does your child say or do when [he/she/they is] upset at home?"

EXPRESSING CONCERN WITHOUT BLAME

- "I'm sharing this because I care about your child's wellbeing."
- "My goal is always to support your child — not to worry you."
- "I want to work with you as a team."
- "This is not about anything wrong with your child — every child has areas where they grow."

DISCUSSING SUPPORT STRATEGIES

- "Here are some things we've tried that have helped."
- "I'd love to hear if any of these strategies work at home."
- "Let's think together about what might help."
- "Would it be okay if we tried [strategy] and checked in next week?"

RECOMMENDING NEXT STEPS

- "There is a free program that might be a good fit for your family."
- "I'd like to share some information about [Early Intervention / CPSE]. Would that be okay?"
- "Your pediatrician is a great first step — here is what I'd suggest mentioning."
- "Let's set up a time to talk again and see how things are going."

RESPONDING TO PARENT WORRY, DENIAL, ANGER, OR SADNESS

- "It makes complete sense that you feel that way."
- "I hear you. Your feelings are valid."
- "I understand this may feel surprising. I'm here to work with you."
- "You don't have to make any decisions today. Let's take this one step at a time."
- "I will follow your lead. What feels right to you?"

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

Instead of saying...	Try saying...
<i>"Your child is aggressive."</i>	<i>"We've noticed that when another child takes a toy, he sometimes pushes or yells. We want to help him learn safe ways to express frustration."</i>
<i>"She has sensory issues."</i>	<i>"We've noticed that loud sounds and messy textures seem uncomfortable for her. We'd like to talk about what helps her feel calm and comfortable."</i>
<i>"He's defiant."</i>	<i>"We've noticed that certain transitions are harder for him. We've been documenting what helps and would love to hear what works at home."</i>
<i>"She's delayed."</i>	<i>"We've noticed some areas where she may benefit from additional support. We'd like to share what we've observed and explore some options together."</i>
<i>"He doesn't listen."</i>	<i>"We've noticed that he sometimes needs extra support following multi-step directions. We have some ideas we'd like to try and hear your thoughts."</i>
<i>"She's just spoiled."</i>	<i>"We've noticed that waiting for her turn is currently a growing edge for her. We're working on some strategies to support her with this."</i>